

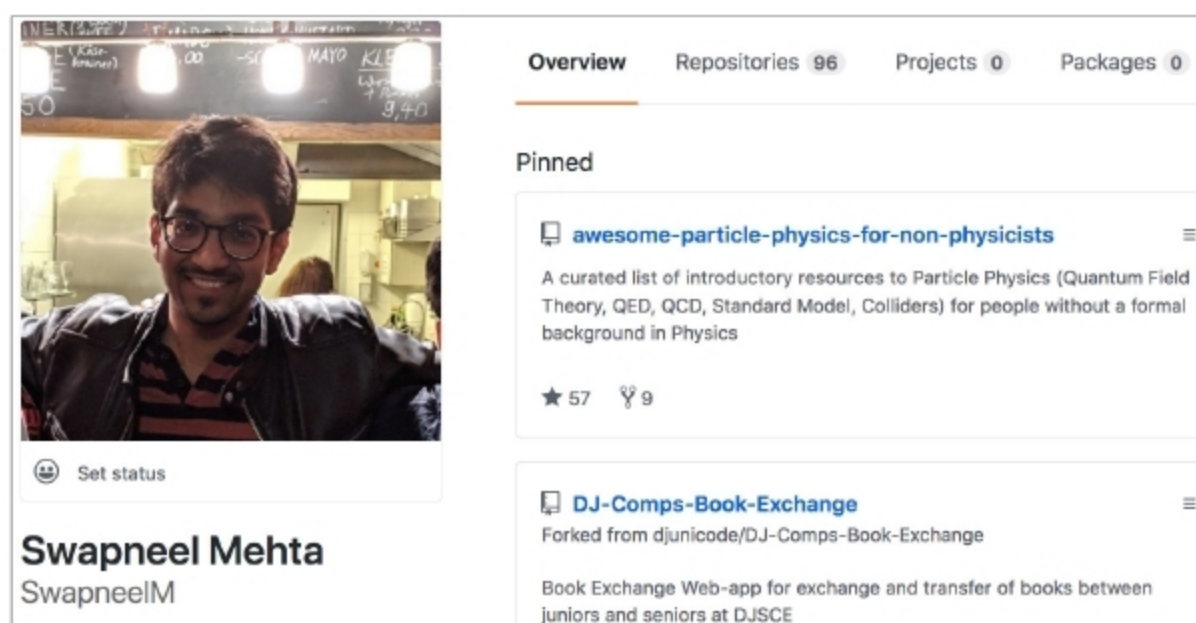


Figure 2: GitHub remains an important indicator of an applicant's capabilities

contacted by a recruiter on a messaging platform after a keyword search of your technical skills, we've come a long way with tech in recruitment. Over the years, the process has undergone a huge shift, currently producing extremely concrete reports of a candidate's performance at each rung of the ladder. There are now tools and resources that allow you to not only practice the same problems that may have been posed to candidates earlier, but also be interviewed by the same people as part of mock sessions — for a fee of course! There are vast sets of problems with detailed solutions available that enable you to gather valuable insight into the interview process of specific companies. In fact, there is a popular book titled 'Cracking the Coding Interview' written by Gayle Laakmann McDowell, a former recruiter at top technology firms, who offers a detailed breakdown of this process.

The availability of all these resources has resulted in an interesting dynamic, which is the tech interview. More recently, there has been a push towards making the interview a more holistic evaluation through take-home problems and subjective discussions of problems as opposed to more objective patterns of questioning. But the aim of all of these processes is a recruiter being able to notice a particular candidate from among hundreds of thousands of applicants, and this remains a challenge.

Enter open source, a one-stop solution for top-level decision-making on evaluating technical expertise.

How does open source relate to employment?

The demand for developers is high but fortunately (or unfortunately, for job seekers) so is the supply. This is particularly true for entry-level developer roles, because of the boot camps, online coursework and the access to resources that allow a non-technical user to gain technical expertise and turn into an active programmer. The problem for recruiters is to find candidates who can actually handle the scale, diversity and the speed at which teams operate, in order to successfully fill vacancies in both big companies and growing startups. The key for candidates is to demonstrate competence by successfully completing projects that are similar to what the hiring firm is looking for. This makes it much easier for their work to be evaluated and to check if they fit in a role, possibly at a larger project and in a bigger organisation. The candidate's experience may not be too relevant, and the project not as big, but still, this approach is preferred to blindly picking candidates with no past experience working in the field.

What open source experience comes with is the idea that a candidate

knows what it's like to pick an idea, work on concreting it, implement it using a programming language, iron out bugs, document the code, make the work reproducible and extendable, and collaborate with a team. This is of huge importance as each of these are skills valued in the industry. It is incredibly difficult to find candidates that check all these boxes; for recruiters, there are always trade-offs to be made. This value that is intrinsic to candidates actively working on open source projects is why GitHub is such a valuable resource for recruiters. There is, of course, an argument against attaching too much value to open source profiles but, for the moment, we will hold off addressing that as it would be getting ahead of ourselves.

"What does open source mean to me?"

Open source is critical when it comes to applying for jobs. It offers a comprehensive breakup of the diverse expertise you have, to potential employers. A look at the projects that you have worked on can help build a rough picture of the trajectory you have taken while finding your way around technology. It is not easy to find a role you love, which is why it is understandable that software developers might switch roles and firms. However, an applicant's exploration has to be driven by a reason and have a meaningful output. Since work-related projects are often proprietary, and hence not sharable with potential recruiters, open source projects are a means to demonstrate that you actually know what you're talking about when it comes to leveraging a particular technology to build a solution.

More than anything else, it is about the reason you work on open source. The rest of this article does a good job of highlighting how important open source is to get you a job, but that's not the real reason most people take up responsibilities on large